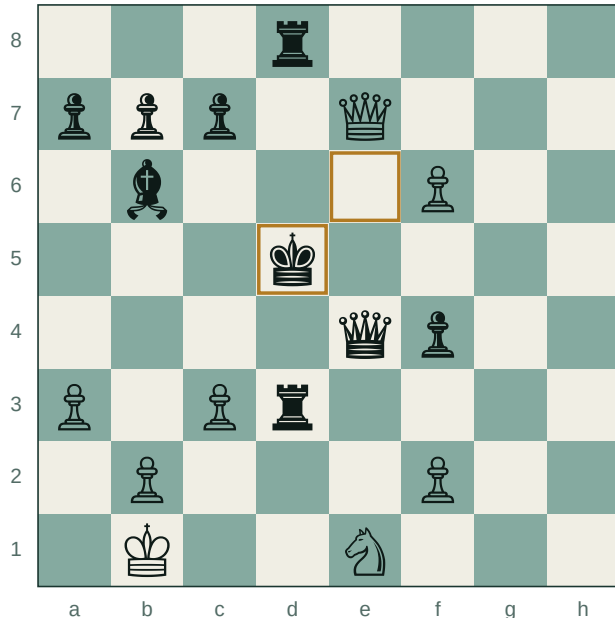


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 32

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 31...Kd5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

32. Qxd8+ Kc6 33. Nxd3

32.Qxd8+ Check restricts Black to 5 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on d8. Recorded reply: **32...Kc6**.

33.Nxd3 The knight captures the rook on d3.

At the end, nominal material is White 17 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +10. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +10: the balance goes from -9 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on d5. Geometrically undefended: rook on d8. Check for tactical protection.